

Overlay Mode

Information and objects interwoven with what you see and hear?

Ram Mohan Rao

Pop-up information balloons in applications can be distracting. But they're useful when you're using the app for the first time. You see "Speaker Mode," and the balloon says "Click this to change output settings."

On TV, you've doubtless seen those arrows and circles overlaid on and around players in a cricket match. "Now this fielder here," says Boycott in his loovly Yorkshire accent, and a red circle appears around the fielder. "Cooms oop to long-on," he continues, and an overlay arrow appears, pointing in the direction of the shift.

So here you have two silly examples of a field of research we'll soon name. But a not-so-silly question: what do the balloons and the arrows have in common?

Figuring the answer requires no great stretch of the imagination. In both cases, information to *augment* your visual focus is being brought in: information to aid you in understanding what you're looking at.

Now let's stretch our imaginations a bit: if information can be overlaid, why not other things? Take your favourite FPS around with you in the real world! Overlay the game—with all its monsters—on what the "real" world is providing your eyes—buildings and all! So as you're walking to work or college, monsters abound—one on the road, one behind your office building...

Notice we said "real" in quotes. That's because the lines are getting blurred—the lines between reality and virtuality. We're going to talk about "Augmented Reality," where you're in the real world and your experience of it is enriched in a useful way. Embedding virtual objects in reality—as in the FPS example—*could* be called Augmented Reality as well, but it's more like "mixed reality." Or should that be "Augmented Virtuality"?

The Terms-And-Definitions Mess

This is not a textbook, and we hate terms and definitions as much as you do. But we do need to get some things straight. Real Reality (hopefully) needs no explanation, but when it does, a professional philosopher needs to step in. We don't have one in-house, so we'll leave that out.

Virtual Reality (VR) is *total immersion* in a world divorced from the reality around you. You're sitting in your room with goggles on, which make it seem *exactly* as though you were on Mars. There's no overlaying of anything anywhere. Period. And that's where we'll leave it at in what follows.

Augmented Virtuality is concerned with systems that primarily recreate virtual environments while introducing elements of reality into the simulation. It's a concept not too many folks are bothered with, so let that be as it is.

Now, there's Augmented Reality (AR); that apart, let's coin a term—Virtual Imagery Superimposed on Top of Actuality (VISTA). It's a nice acronym, because it does mean new vistas of experience... and this is a nice place to get started.

More Real Than Real

You've seen it on TV, like we said: now imagine being in the stadium—somewhere in the back seats—when a cricket match is on. In the year 2020, our favourite year of the future. You're wearing comical-looking goggles, dangling cables and all.

Imaging: Shikrishna Patkar
Photograph: Anurag Patkar

Type : Monument
Name : Gateway of India
Interest : Architecture; History

Type : Lights
Time On : 19:30
Time Off : 06:00

Flag: India

Type : Hotel
Name : Taj
Acc : No
Contact : 91-22-98765432

Type : Structure
Architecture: British
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Type : Ship
Name : INS Veer
Status : Docked

Type : Transport
Name : Ferry
Status: Elephantia

Type : Jeans
Brand: Guess
Store: S. P. Mall
Price: Rs 1,400
Discount: No

Type :
Brand:

